‘But there should be a failure probability.’ Dhawan would not let me go so easily.

‘Zero per cent,’ I replied.

Dhawan smiled.

I knew if the test failed, I had to go. I had decided on this. With my experience and the Princeton trophy of a course certificate, a job abroad was an easy proposition. But working in a foreign country did not excite me. One option was to teach. I loved teaching. But running away was not done, especially since I had come all this way.

There are a thousand reasons a ground test can fail, and often it happens because of something we had not foreseen. But, in this case, a failure would have meant that I had misguided my colleagues including the ISRO chairman, who had immense faith in me. Despite my options outside ISRO, I realised, now I had to stay put to prove a point.

Now, preparations were in full swing to transport the engine to France. It was not an easy job. There were parts huge and small, from the turbo pump in one piece to tiny nuts and bolts.

I was worried about the packing, after the experience of returning from Vernon. Our household articles were professionally packed and shipped back to India, but many of them reached India mangled. Our teams ensured that no such thing would happen with the engine parts. With prescribed metal clamps, felt, buffers and cushions to hold the pieces in place without damage, we packed them all into twenty-one boxes.

Air India was to fly the engine to Paris, but since there was no direct flight from Trivandrum, the boxes were to be loaded in Trivandrum, unloaded in Mumbai where they would be loaded again into another flight that goes to Paris. DS was to make the arrangements with Air India.

When the boxes finally reached the Trivandrum airport, one of them was found to be just the size of the door of the aircraft’s cargo hold. It would fit in there at the door, but couldn’t be pushed inside without damaging the beading. The brilliant space scientists realised that they had never bothered to check the size of the aircraft’s door before packing the engine!